



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

IN WEST HOLLYWOOD, A COYOTE DREAM HOUSE

This abandoned construction site is home to new residents prone to loud parties at night. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

FEDERAL RAIDS OCCUR ACROSS SOCAL

FBI actions are said to be linked to an inquiry into corruption and foreign influence.

By RICHARD WINTON

A series of FBI raids this week involving San Bernardino County elected officials and a Chinese-language media company are part of growing probes into public corruption and foreign influence in Southern California, law enforcement sources say.

FBI agents executed warrants across Southern California, searching the homes and offices of a San Bernardino County supervisor, an Ontario City Council member and the offices of EDI Media, a well-known Chinese-U.S. media producer based in West Covina.

The feds also raided a Beverly Hills mansion owned by a Chinese family and obtained records at Ontario International Airport.

FBI officials confirmed the search warrant addresses but did not name the individuals subject to the searches, saying the affidavits for the warrants are under seal. The FBI and U.S. attorney's office declined to comment on the reasons for the investigations, citing the sealed warrants. No one was arrested.

But the raids come amid deepening federal investigations into allegations of connections between local government officials and agents of the Chinese government. Most of those targeted by the FBI activities did not return calls seeking comment.

In May, the former mayor of Arcadia pleaded guilty to accusations that she was directed by the Chinese government to promote propaganda in the United States. Authorities alleged she [See **FBI**, A6]

A surprising twist in return-to-office effort

By ROGER VINCENT

Los Angeles video gaming company Riot Games abandoned its return-to-office requirements in January, and surprisingly, more of its employees have been showing up at work.

Two years of dictating that everyone commute into work on Tuesdays, Wednesdays and Thursdays was hurting the morale as well as the productivity of many. Riot decided on a radical revamp of its policies to allow more flexibility, said Riot President Hoby Darling.

"The companywide cadence was too rigid and didn't reflect the different ways teams work and didn't bring people together for the moments that could have the most impact," he said. "Our goal was never to create rules for their own sake. It

was to create the environment where Riot is the best place to make games."

The company pivoted from a three-days-per-week requirement to a roughly three-days-per-month expectation, with each team leader deciding when more attendance is mandatory depending on when people need to be in person with their team.

More than seven months into the new policy, the results have been impressive, the company said. Attendance and productivity have risen.

The Los Angeles metropolitan area and other big California population centers are below the national average in office attendance, according to Kastle Systems, which [See **Riot Games**, A11]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

RIOT GAMES has long tried to entice staff with perks such as a coffee bar.

State aims to steady EV sales

California launches an instant rebate program after federal aid to car buyers was eliminated.

By KAREN GARCIA

With gas prices remaining high because of the war in Iran, California officials are hoping a new rebate program for electric cars can make the math work for buyers at a time when federal incentives have gone away under the Trump administration.

California has long been the leader in electric-vehicle

adoption, which has continued this year despite the elimination of federal tax credits.

The state is now poised to assist drivers with the purchase of their first new or used electric vehicle, starting next month.

The MyFirstEV instant rebate program, the state's latest push toward getting more EVs on the road, will knock \$3,500 off the purchase price of a new EV and \$1,750 off a used model.

Experts say the program is meant to provide a shot in the arm for EV sales in the state but might not move the needle much at a time when the supply of electric vehi-

cles is low nationwide. EV prices remain higher in general than those of gas-powered cars, and that has been a barrier to new adoption for those with low or moderate incomes.

This month, the California Energy Commission announced that during the second quarter of the year — April through June — Californians purchased 86,857 new zero-emission vehicles — 75,597 people bought EVs, 11,179 bought plug-in hybrids, and 81 purchased hydrogen fuel-cell vehicles.

This represents 19.1% of new car sales in the state and [See **EVs**, A10]

Random stops, 'stunts' marked ICE raids in L.A.

Court exhibits reveal officers worried about legality of their actions, being too aggressive.

By BRITTNY MEJIA,
CLARA HARTER
AND RUBEN VIVES

Little was known about how federal immigration enforcement operations were coordinated in Los Angeles last year.

But that changed this week when hundreds of pages of court exhibits — released through discovery in a federal lawsuit — provided a glimpse into the operations.

They revealed random, rather than targeted, stops, a casual use of racial slurs, and apparent frustration among a few officers who feared they were being asked to break the law.

The exhibits were included in a motion for a preliminary injunction filed Monday by the American Civil Liberties Union of Southern California, Public Counsel, and other groups and private attorneys seeking to bar an "ongoing cam-

paign of suspicionless and discriminatory detective stops" in the Central District of California.

Among the newly released records is the testimony of a Border Patrol agent who described how officers selected the site of a June 18, 2025, raid at a Whittier car wash. According to the agent, the team searched Google for nearby car washes and the Whittier business was chosen because "that was one of the places that came on the list as the nearest location."

The following month, when a phalanx of Border Patrol agents showed up outside a news conference held by leading California Democrats — including Gov. Gavin Newsom — a Homeland Security Investigations agent texted another agent that the operation was "political" and "a stunt."

A Homeland Security spokesperson at the time claimed that agents were "focused on enforcing the law, not on [Newsom]."

But the agent saw it otherwise, observing that Border Patrol "essentially raided the Newsom press conferences."

[See **Raids**, A7]

UC admits record California class

Number of state residents accepted rises. New data also show racial shifts.

By JAWEED KALEEM

The University of California offered seats to a record number of Californians this year, according to figures released Wednesday, as it faces intense scrutiny of its admissions practices, including pressure from Sacramento to enroll more state residents and investigations by the Trump administration.

UC admitted 102,031 California first-year students for the fall, an increase of 1,458 from last year. In another record, it offered seats to 29,372 transfer students from California community colleges.

Overall, the nine-undergraduate-campus system accepted 78% of the Californians who applied as first-year students. But acceptance rates varied widely at campuses across the state.

UC Berkeley and UCLA each admitted about 1 in 10 applicants. UC Davis took

nearly half of those who applied. Merced admitted nearly everyone who met UC's academic requirements.

A university compact with the state ties its funding increases to enrollment growth. Under that agreement, the system must add at least 1% more California undergraduates each year. UC is outpacing that and says it is on track to reach its goal of enrolling 217,000 California resident undergraduates by 2030. There were 200,532 California undergraduates attending UC last fall, out of a total of 237,616 undergraduates and 301,093 students overall.

"For generations, a University of California education has been one of the state's most powerful engines of social mobility, opening doors for talented students from every background and region of the state," UC President James B. Milliken said in a statement. "The record number of California students we're welcoming this year reflects UC's enduring commitment to expanding opportunity while preparing the next generation of leaders, innovation." [See **UC**, A6]



ALLISON ROBERT Associated Press

FAUCI INVOKES THE 5TH

Dr. Anthony Fauci declined to answer questions in a tense Senate committee hearing, citing the antagonism of Republican Rand Paul. **NATION, A5**

Lineage files for permit to rebuild

The company called it a normal part of repairs, but residents and local officials have expressed outrage. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Turning sunny; warm.
L.A. Basin: 87/68. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

Ohtani's return timeline unclear

Despite injuries, two-way player could still pitch again this season. **SPORTS, B10**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



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Beach alert: Sharks can hear you coming

By ROSANNA XIA

Forget the smell of blood and all the shark fears we've internalized thanks to "Jaws" and "Shark Week." Turns out, the first thing a shark notices about humans actually might be the unique sounds we make in the ocean.

And great white sharks — at least the ones in a sharky hot spot like Southern California — have really,

really good hearing. Whether you're swimming or kayaking or paddling on your surfboard, even a juvenile can detect you from as far as 100 feet away.

Although this might sound like the start to another horror movie — especially with more sharks and more people seeking respite in the ocean amid record-breaking heat waves and a looming El Niño — there is good news. A new study shows that even though

sharks react to human noises, they often can tell from just our splashing that we're not worth the nibble.

"There are dozens — if not potentially hundreds — of encounters daily at a beach with a lot of sharks and people. Why aren't people being bitten? How do we explain this?" said Chris Lowe, director of the celebrated Shark Lab at Cal State Long Beach. "We worked our way through all the different senses that a

shark could use to go, 'that's a person,' and we thought sound and vibration might be the most influential one."

For years, Lowe and his lab have documented white sharks getting very close to people in the water. The shark's approach is never rushed or aggressive — it's more like something piques the shark's curiosity from dozens of feet away, and then as the shark creeps in closer to investigate, it loses inter-

[See **Sharks**, A6]